

ZARDARI

converted into law, the ordinance had already lapsed. Yet thousands of criminal and corruption cases against politicians and government bureaucrats were closed in the wake of its promulgation, including, most prominently, those against Bhutto and her husband Zardari, both accused of large-scale corruption.

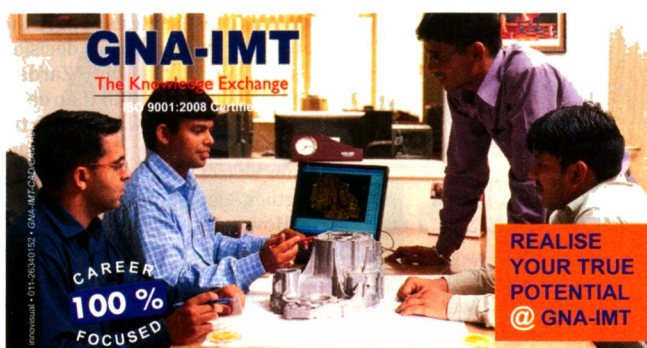
The Supreme Court's decision holds the NRO in direct conflict with the constitution and *void ab initio*, in effect meaning that it will be considered never to have existed. Subsequently, all cases closed under it stand revived, as do all convictions set aside. Apart from Zardari, the people who will face the brunt of this decision immediately are some of his closest associates, cur-

rent Interior Minister Rehman Malik and the President's Principal Secretary Salman Farooqui, both former bureaucrats who had corruption cases against them set aside under the NRO. Since both were declared fugitives—they had fled Pakistan in the '90s to escape what they had termed "politically motivated cases"—they are now under threat of arrest. Even if they are not arrested, the clamour for all "NRO-tainted" government officials—in the words of opposition politician Imran Khan—to resign will surely grow.

President Zardari's position may not be under immediate threat. He may enjoy Presidential immunity from prosecution, a point still to be arbitrated by

the courts, and the prospect of impeachment is remote, but the moral pressure on him to step aside has suddenly reached gargantuan proportions. His name has already been dragged through the mud during the court's proceedings, with accusations against him—such as the siphoning off of more than \$1.5 billion in kickbacks and commissions—receiving fresh airing in the media, although he continues to insist that these were "manufactured and untrue allegations." The latest to add to that pressure is parliamentarian Khawaja Asif, one of the main leaders of the opposition Pakistan Muslim League (N) and considered a close confidante of former premier Nawaz Sharif, hitherto considered "the friendly opposition." As soon as the decision against the NRO was announced, Asif called on Zardari to resign.

The presidential camp has dismissed all such demands as "unfounded" and a "joke", but there is little doubt that the presidency is unnerved. Of particular concern is the



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